
AI Governance around the world

Country Profile: United Kingdom

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About The Alan Turing Institute

The Alan Turing Institute is the UK's national institute for data science and artificial intelligence.

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About the project

Introduction

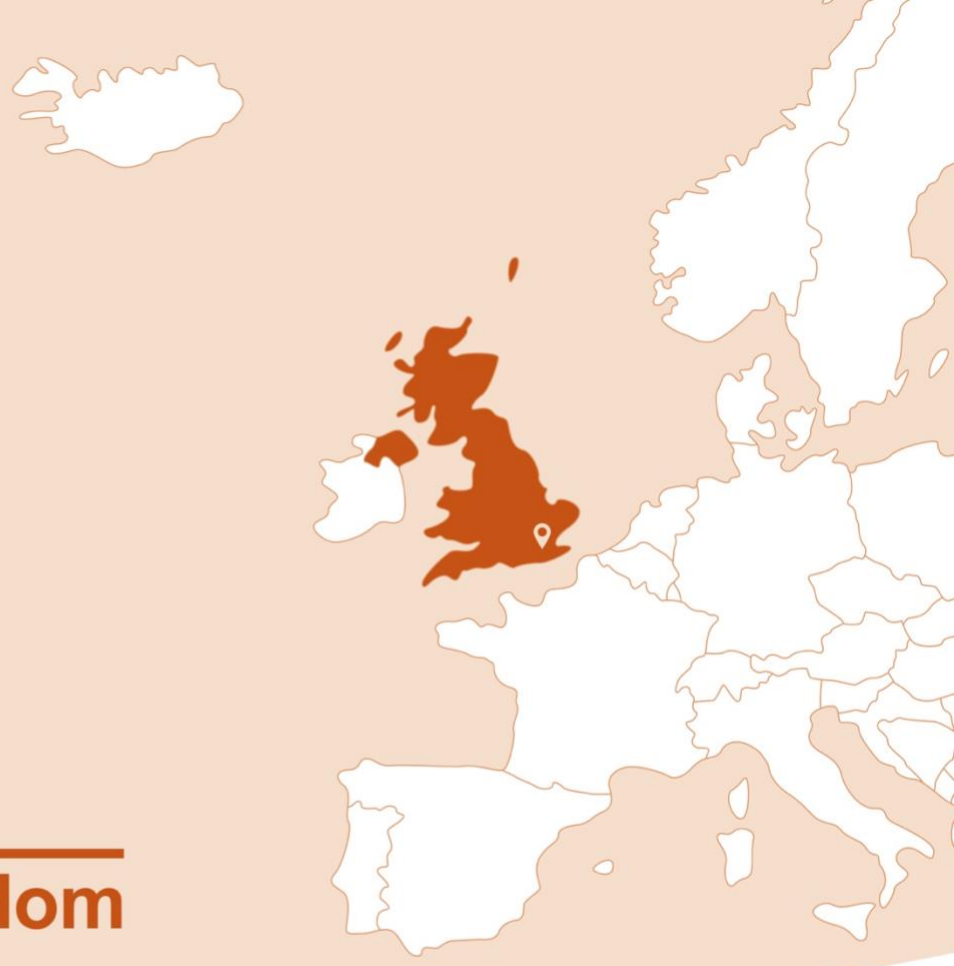
The international AI governance landscape continues to evolve as jurisdictions around the world balance the need to navigate increased competition with earlier commitments to advancing international alignment and cooperation on AI governance and safety. Many jurisdictions have recognised the strategic implications of AI, both for economic prosperity and national security, and accelerated investment in domestic AI infrastructure has begun to engender a more competitive international environment. However, the role of international trade and global cooperation remains crucial in realising the economic benefits of AI while effectively managing the technology's risks.

As high-level AI principles are translated into concrete policies and distinct regulatory frameworks, jurisdictions are managing the tensions between competitive and cooperative priorities. Meaningful progress towards effective international AI governance will require a clear and detailed understanding of how different countries are approaching AI governance in practice. Tracking primary source policy initiatives over the past decade, the *AI governance around the world* project sheds light on shifting national priorities on AI, dynamics of cooperation and competition, and potential areas of international alignment.

Project aims

The *AI governance around the world* project seeks to map this evolving landscape through a series of country profiles based on a consistent framework. Each profile provides a descriptive overview of a jurisdiction's approach to AI regulation and standardisation, highlighting the high-level aims and principles, definitions of relevant technologies, key policy initiatives and the main features of the respective standardisation systems. Drawing exclusively on primary sources, the country profiles analyse legal and policy instruments, national strategies, standardisation initiatives, and public investments that reflect the varied and evolving approaches that different jurisdictions are taking to AI governance.

This series offers a foundation for comparative analysis and future work on global regulatory interoperability without commenting on the efficacy of the specific governance models being adopted at the jurisdictional level. As more profiles are developed, the project aims to contribute to international understanding of where alignment is emerging and where deeper coordination may be needed.



United Kingdom

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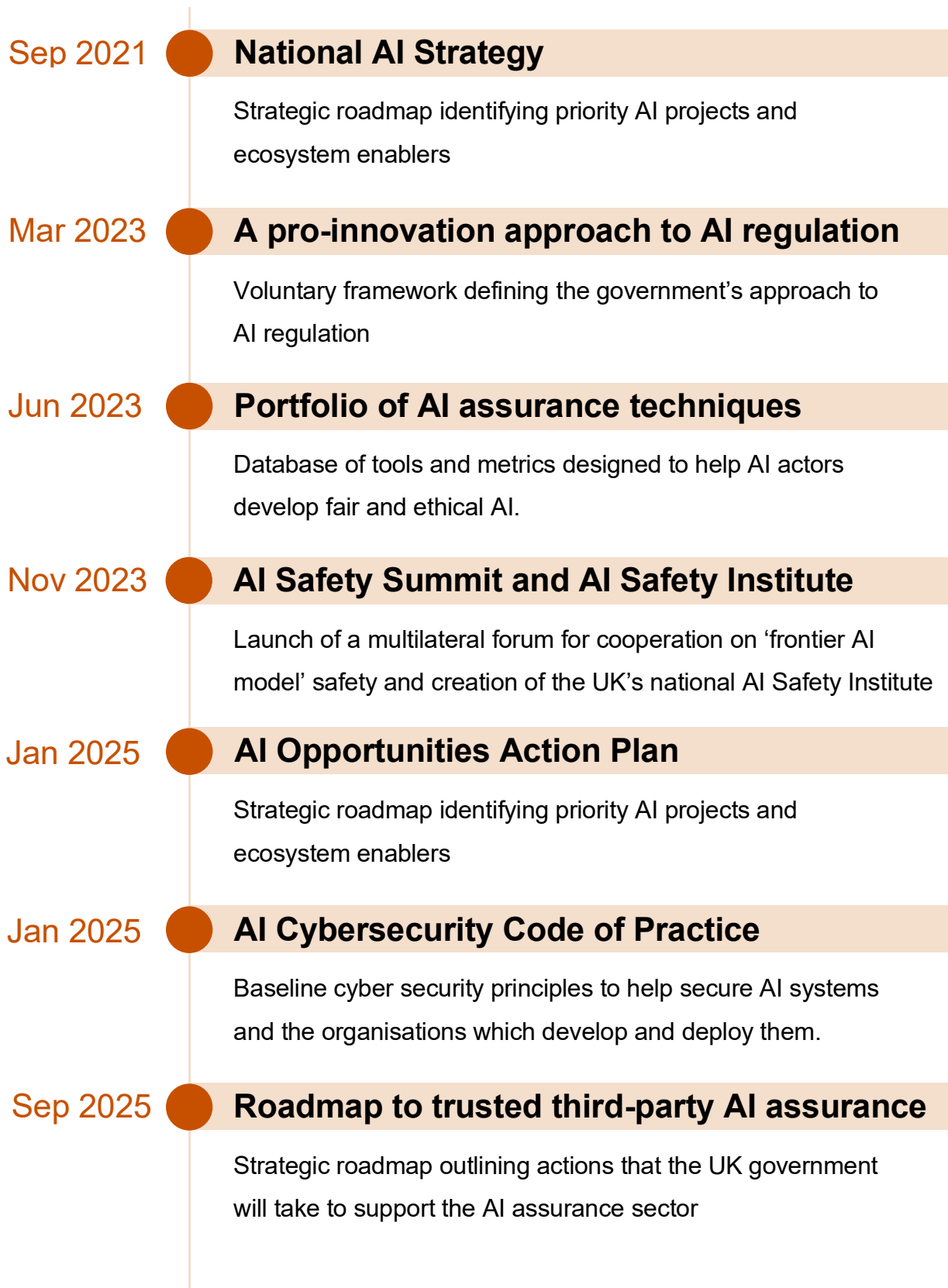
Executive summary



The UK has established itself as one of the most proactive jurisdictions in AI governance, operating on both domestic and international fronts. At the national level, the government has adopted a principle-based, voluntary framework that relies on regulators to develop sector-specific guidance, rather than imposing rigid horizontal legislation. This is complemented by significant initiatives to strengthen the AI assurance and safety ecosystem, paired with investments into compute infrastructure. Internationally, the UK has positioned itself as a global convener, driving multilateral cooperation to address the risks of advanced AI models while promoting shared safety protocols.

Standards form a strategic cornerstone of this governance approach. Because they are flexible, voluntary, and useful to translate high-level principles into technical specifications, standards are viewed as valuable tools to support interoperability between different national regimes and advance the UK government's AI policy priorities. Recognising this strategic value, the government actively promotes standards in multilateral forums and supports domestic stakeholders to strengthen British influence on international standardisation for AI.

Timeline



Regulatory Approach to AI

High-level aims and principles

Published in 2021, the UK's *National AI Strategy* set the government's AI policy goals for the next decade.¹ The Strategy articulates the government's vision and goals under a three-pillar structure. As part of Pillar One, the government committed to strengthening the country's 'leadership as a science and AI superpower' by investing and planning for the long-term needs of the AI ecosystem. This includes setting up key enablers of a dynamic AI sector to attract and retain AI businesses. As part of Pillar Two, the government committed to supporting the transition to an 'AI-enabled economy' across all sectors and regions of the UK. Under Pillar Three, the government stated the objective of developing effective national and international frameworks for the governance of AI.

The UK government's regulatory approach is detailed in the March 2023 white paper *A pro-innovation approach to AI regulation*.² Building on the OECD values-based AI principles, this approach is underpinned by five overarching principles: safety, security, and robustness; appropriate transparency and explainability; fairness; accountability and governance; and contestability and redress.

After a change in government in July 2024, the new administration has published a new strategic roadmap for AI—the *AI Opportunities Action Plan*.³ While in continuity with the flexible and light-touch approach laid out in the *National AI Strategy* and in the AI regulation white paper, this roadmap adds a layer of active industrial strategy and commits the government to focus specifically on AI adoption and economic growth. Its three overarching goals are to:

- Build the foundations for AI to scale across the country.
- Accelerate AI adoption in both the public and private sectors.
- Build sovereign frontier AI capabilities.

Definitions of relevant technologies

The UK government has adopted a broad, high-level definition of AI. In its 2023 AI regulation white paper, the government defines 'AI, AI systems or AI technologies' as "products and services that are 'adaptable' and 'autonomous'".⁴ In this context, adaptivity refers to the ability of AI systems to perform new forms of inference not

directly envisioned by their human programmers at the time of training. Autonomy, instead, refers to the ability of some AI systems to make decisions without the express intent or ongoing control of a human. This flexibility ensures that the regulatory framework remains relevant as technology evolves.

A notable exception is the *National Security and Investment Act (NSI Act)*. Because the Act is a law with legally binding requirements, it employs a more precise definition. It defines AI as a “technology enabling the programming or training of a device or software to (i) perceive environments through the use of data; (ii) interpret data using automated processing designed to approximate cognitive abilities; (iii) make recommendations, predictions or decisions, with a view to achieving a specific objective.”⁵ Crucially, this stricter definition applies only to the scope of the *NSI Act*.

Key policy initiatives

Since the publication of its *National AI Strategy*, the UK government has launched several significant policy initiatives. Early efforts focused on strengthening the AI assurance ecosystem and consulting on regulatory design. This culminated in the 2023 publication of the AI regulation white paper, a voluntary framework for the development and use of AI. This framework is underpinned by five AI regulation principles whose practical implementation is delegated to sector-specific regulators. Through a dedicated central function, the government coordinates and supports regulators while monitoring the implementation of the framework.

The recently elected Labour Government broadly reaffirmed this sector-specific approach in the *AI Opportunities Action Plan*.⁶ The plan commits government departments to work proactively with regulators to identify future AI capability needs and provide clear strategic direction. It also pledges support for ‘pro-innovation initiatives’ like regulatory sandboxes.

¹ GOV.UK, ‘National AI Strategy’, September 2021, <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/national-ai-strategy>.

² GOV.UK, ‘A pro-innovation approach to AI regulation’, August 2023, <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/ai-regulation-a-pro-innovation-approach/white-paper>.

³ GOV.UK, ‘PM speech on AI Opportunities Action Plan’, January 2025, <https://www.gov.uk/government/speeches/pm-speech-on-ai-opportunities-action-plan-13-january-2025>.

⁴ ‘A pro-innovation approach to AI regulation’, cit.

⁵ GOV.UK, ‘National security and investment: mandatory notification sectors’, November 2020, <https://www.gov.uk/government/consultations/national-security-and-investment-mandatory-notification-sectors>.

⁶ GOV.UK, ‘AI Opportunities Action Plan’, January 2025, <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/ai-opportunities-action-plan/ai-opportunities-action-plan>.

A key example of this is the *AI Growth Lab*. Working with regulators, the Lab aims to operate issue-specific sandboxes in priority sectors to “carefully supervise the deployment of AI-enabled products and services that current regulation hinders”.⁷ The Lab is part of a blueprint for ‘cutting red tape’ and promoting responsible innovation, reflecting the government’s pro-growth agenda.⁸

Parallel to these initiatives, the government has signalled its intention to introduce mandatory rules addressing the risks of the most advanced AI models. If successful, this initiative would substantially alter the non-statutory nature of the UK government’s current approach to AI regulation.

At the international level, the UK hosted the inaugural AI Safety Summit, establishing a multilateral forum for cooperation on ‘frontier AI model’ safety. The Summit led to the creation of the UK AI Safety Institute (UKAISi)—more recently rebranded AI Security Institute—and prompted other nations to establish similar bodies dedicated to evaluating emerging AI risks and advising governments on appropriate measures to address them.

Horizontal initiatives

A pro-innovation approach to AI regulation

The *AI regulation white paper* (2023) outlines the first framework for AI regulation developed by the UK government. Building on the *National AI Strategy* and the preliminary policy paper *Establishing a pro-innovation approach to AI regulation* (2022), aims to support “responsible innovation [...], strengthen the UK’s position as a global leader in AI, harness AI’s ability to drive growth and prosperity, and increase public trust in its use and applications.”⁹

The framework is characterised by four key features:

1. It is principle-based because it sets five cross-cutting principles to guide UK regulators in developing consistent sectoral approaches to AI regulation.
2. It avoids immediate AI-specific legislation. Instead, the government proposed a non-statutory period to assess the effectiveness of existing laws, though it

⁷ GOV.UK, ‘AI Growth Lab’, October 2025, <https://www.gov.uk/government/calls-for-evidence/ai-growth-lab/ai-growth-lab>.

⁸ GOV.UK, ‘New approach to ensure regulators and regulation support growth’, October 2025, <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/a-new-approach-to-ensure-regulators-and-regulation-support-growth/new-approach-to-ensure-regulators-and-regulation-support-growth.html>.

⁹ ‘A pro-innovation approach to AI regulation’, cit.

retains the option to introduce a statutory duty for regulators or ad-hoc legislation if gaps emerge.

3. It is context-dependent. By rejecting horizontal legislation in favour of sector-specific interventions, the government acknowledges that AI risks vary by use case and are best managed by regulators with specific domain expertise.
4. It relies on central functions established within the Department for Science Innovation and Technology (DSIT). These functions ensure coherence by monitoring the framework, conducting horizon scanning, supporting regulatory sandboxes, and fostering international interoperability.

In its response to a public consultation that ran from March to June 2023, the government reaffirmed its commitment to this flexible model.¹⁰ However, it introduced a significant caveat regarding General Purpose AI (GPAI) models, suggesting that unique risks posed by these technologies may require a bespoke regulatory approach involving binding rules.

AI Safety Summit and UK AI Security Institute

In November 2023, the UK hosted the inaugural *AI Safety Summit*¹¹, an intergovernmental process established to facilitate international cooperation on the risks associated with ‘frontier AI’—defined as highly capable general-purpose models that match or exceed today’s most advanced models.¹²

Going into the Summit, the UK government published five key objectives:

1. Achieving a shared understanding of frontier AI and the specific risks of concern.
2. Establishing a forward process of international collaboration on frontier AI safety, including how best to support national and international frameworks.
3. Agreeing on appropriate measures that individual organisations should take to increase frontier AI safety.
4. Identifying areas for potential collaboration on AI safety research, including evaluating model capabilities and the development of new standards to support governance.
5. Showcasing how to ensure the safe development and use of AI for the public good.

¹⁰ GOV.UK, ‘A pro-innovation approach to AI regulation: government response’, February 2024, <https://www.gov.uk/government/consultations/ai-regulation-a-pro-innovation-approach-policy-proposals/outcome/a-pro-innovation-approach-to-ai-regulation-government-response>.

¹¹ GOV.UK, ‘AI Safety Summit 2023’, November 2023, <https://www.gov.uk/government/topical-events/ai-safety-summit-2023>.

¹² GOV.UK, ‘Frontier AI: capabilities and risks – discussion paper’, October 2023, <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/frontier-ai-capabilities-and-risks-discussion-paper/frontier-ai-capabilities-and-risks-discussion-paper>.

Key outcomes of the Summit included the *Bletchley Declaration*, which committed participating countries to establish a shared scientific understanding of the safety risks associated with frontier AI;¹³ the publication of a *State of AI Science* report;¹⁴ a joint statement on AI safety testing where participating nations committed to developing state-led evaluations and safety research; and the publication of internal AI safety policies by leading AI labs.

The Summit also directly influenced domestic policy, leading to the creation of the *AI Safety Institute*¹⁵. Born out of a restructuring of the previous *Frontier AI Taskforce*, the UKASI was created to assess the potential risks of advanced AI models and was given a threefold mandate:

- To evaluate the safety-relevant capabilities of advanced AI models.
- To conduct foundational AI safety research to support innovative governance solutions.
- To facilitate the exchange of information between policymakers, industry organisations, academia and civil society at both national and international levels.

In February 2025, UKASI rebranded to become the UK AI Security Institute and announced new workstreams focusing on adversarial use cases, including chemical/bioweapons, cyber-attacks, fraud, and child exploitation.¹⁶

AI Assurance initiatives

Published by the *Responsible Technology Adoption Unit* (RTA, formerly CDEI) and DSIT as part of the UK's *National AI Strategy*, the *Roadmap to an effective AI assurance ecosystem* outlines key steps to establish a system of tools and services needed to ensure AI systems function as intended.¹⁷ The Roadmap identifies six priority areas:

1. Demand: strengthening demand for AI assurance services.
2. Market: building a competitive and dynamic AI assurance market.

¹³ GOV.UK, 'The Bletchley Declaration by Countries Attending the AI Safety Summit', November 2023, <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/ai-safety-summit-2023-the-bletchley-declaration/the-bletchley-declaration-by-countries-attending-the-ai-safety-summit-1-2-november-2023>.

¹⁴ GOV.UK, 'International Scientific Report on the Safety of Advanced AI', May 2024, <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/international-scientific-report-on-the-safety-of-advanced-ai>.

¹⁵ GOV.UK, 'Introducing the AI Safety Institute', January 2024, <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/ai-safety-institute-overview/introducing-the-ai-safety-institute>.

¹⁶ GOV.UK, 'Tackling AI security risks to unleash growth and deliver Plan for Change', February 2025, <https://www.gov.uk/government/news/tackling-ai-security-risks-to-unleash-growth-and-deliver-plan-for-change>.

¹⁷ GOV.UK (2021), 'The roadmap to an effective AI assurance ecosystem', December 2021, <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/the-roadmap-to-an-effective-ai-assurance-ecosystem>.

3. Standards: developing standards to build a common language and scalable assessment techniques.
4. Accreditation: establishing accreditation schemes for AI assurance providers.
5. Regulation: adopting regulation to support the development of the broader AI assurance ecosystem.
6. Research: advancing independent research on AI assurance tools and services.

To support practical implementation, the RTA and DSIT published the *Portfolio of AI assurance techniques* in June 2023.¹⁸ This database of case studies maps technical and procedural techniques to the principles in the AI regulation white paper. To further facilitate understanding of AI assurance and promote good practice across sectors, DSIT is also developing a series of sector-specific guidance. The first guidance on procuring and deploying AI for recruitment was published in March 2024.

In November 2024, DSIT published *Assuring a responsible future for AI* – an economic analysis of the AI assurance market exploring its future potential, identifying growth opportunities, and setting out targeted actions the government will take to support it.¹⁹ This analysis identified the need for:

- Building an AI assurance platform to help developers navigate the landscape.
- Setting out a roadmap to trusted third-party AI assurance.
- Collaborating with UKAIS to advance assurance research.
- Developing common terminology aligned with OECD AI Principles.

Following up on these findings, DSIT published the *Roadmap to trusted third-party AI assurance* in November 2025, outlining interventions to remove market barriers for firms that perform independent verification of AI systems and support assurance professionals.²⁰

AI Opportunities Action Plan

The *AI Opportunities Action Plan* (2025) sets out the roadmap of the newly elected Labour government to leverage AI for economic growth and public service reform.²¹ Commissioned by the Secretary of State for Science, Innovation and Technology and

¹⁸ GOV.UK, 'Portfolio of AI assurance techniques', June 2023, <https://www.gov.uk/guidance/portfolio-of-ai-assurance-techniques>.

¹⁹ GOV.UK, 'Assuring a Responsible Future for AI', November 2024, <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/assuring-a-responsible-future-for-ai/assuring-a-responsible-future-for-ai>.

²⁰ GOV.UK, 'Trusted third-party AI assurance roadmap', September 2025, <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/trusted-third-party-ai-assurance-roadmap/trusted-third-party-ai-assurance-roadmap>.

²¹ 'AI Opportunities Action Plan', cit.

led by Matt Clifford OBE, the plan pivots the national focus from safety-centric discourse to supporting AI adoption.

The plan comprises 50 recommendations and is structured across three pillars:

1. Establishing AI foundations, including by designating *AI Growth Zones* with streamlined planning for building and operating data centres, creating a *National Data Library* to leverage public sector data assets for model training, training and attracting the next generation of AI talent, and instructing regulators to focus on enabling safe innovation.
2. Advancing AI adoption, including by introducing an agile 'Scan>Pilot>Scale' approach to improve innovation in public services, launching new public-private partnerships, and addressing AI adoption barriers in the private sector.
3. Harvesting national champions at the frontier of AI capabilities, including by creating a *Sovereign AI Unit* within government to support new and existing frontier AI companies within the UK.

In its official response, the government accepted the plan's 50 recommendations, signalling a move toward an industrial strategy that relies on AI as a primary driver of economic growth.²² This plan confirms the 'light touch' regulatory approach adopted by the previous administration, complementing it with active state intervention to shape the market and build national capabilities.

AI Cybersecurity Code of Practice

In January 2025, DSIT published the *AI Cybersecurity Code of Practice*, a framework to manage security risks across the AI supply chain.²³ The Code highlights high-priority risks, including data poisoning, model obfuscation, and indirect prompt injection. To mitigate these risks, the Code sets out 13 principles promoting objectives such as security-by-design, human oversight, and accountability. Crucially for implementation, each principle is signposted to relevant international standards.

Vertical initiatives

The UK government relies on a context-specific approach, entrusting sectoral regulators to operationalise the five AI principles within their remits. Several regulators have already published AI-specific guidance and research. For example, the MHRA

²² GOV.UK, 'Government response to the AI Opportunities Action Plan', January 2025, <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/ai-opportunities-action-plan-government-response/ai-opportunities-action-plan-government-response>.

²³ GOV.UK, Code of Practice for the Cyber Security of AI, January 2025, <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/ai-cyber-security-code-of-practice/code-of-practice-for-the-cyber-security-of-ai>.

published a roadmap for AI embedded in medical devices,²⁴ the EHRC released guidance on the use of AI by public bodies,²⁵ and the ONR published a roadmap for regulating AI in the nuclear sector.²⁶

Given the breadth of this landscape, this report focuses on the most important initiatives adopted by the four regulators comprising the *Digital Regulation Cooperation Forum* (DRCF). The DRCF has identified AI governance as a primary focus, and its members –the CMA, FCA, ICO, and Ofcom–have been instrumental in driving some of the most important regulatory developments in AI.

Competition and Markets Authority (CMA)

The CMA is the UK’s principal competition and consumer protection regulator. It has actively monitored the intersection of AI and market dynamics since 2021, when it published its first research on the potential for algorithms to reduce competition and harm consumers.²⁷

More recently, the regulator has focused on the risks posed by foundation models. Through reports published in 2023²⁸ and 2024,²⁹ the CMA warned about significant risks to competition in the foundation model market. To mitigate these risks, it proposed a set of principles to guide the development of these models in a way that preserves competition and consumer choice.

In July 2025, the CMA published the results of its market investigation into the state of competition in the cloud services market. The investigation highlighted significant market concentration and recommended decisive action, leveraging the enhanced enforcement powers granted to the regulator by the *Digital Markets, Competition and Consumers Act 2024*.

²⁴ GOV.UK, ‘Software and artificial intelligence (AI) as a medical device’, February 2025, <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/software-and-artificial-intelligence-ai-as-a-medical-device/software-and-artificial-intelligence-ai-as-a-medical-device>.

²⁵ EHRC, ‘New guidance on AI and equality available to public sector bodies’, September 2024, <https://www.equalityhumanrights.com/new-guidance-ai-and-equality-available-public-sector-bodies>.

²⁶ ONR, ‘ONR shares pro-innovation approach to regulating AI in the nuclear sector’, April 2024, <https://www.onr.org.uk/news/all-news/2024/04/onr-shares-pro-innovation-approach-to-regulating-ai-in-the-nuclear-sector>.

²⁷ GOV.UK, ‘Algorithms: How they can reduce competition and harm consumers’, January 2021, <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/algorithms-how-they-can-reduce-competition-and-harm-consumers/algorithms-how-they-can-reduce-competition-and-harm-consumers>.

²⁸ GOV.UK, ‘AI Foundation Models: Initial report’, September 2023, <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/ai-foundation-models-initial-report>.

²⁹ GOV.UK, ‘AI Foundation Models: Update paper’, April 2024, <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/ai-foundation-models-update-paper>.

Financial Conduct Authority (FCA)

The FCA—the UK’s financial services regulator—has published a series of joint documents with the Bank of England, where it exemplifies its approach to AI regulation. These include the *AI Discussion Paper* (2022),³⁰ the *AI Public-Private Forum Final report* (2022),³¹ and the *Feedback Statement – AI and machine learning* (2023).³² These documents outline a technology-agnostic approach. Rather than creating a bespoke AI framework, the FCA relies on existing financial services regulation to mitigate risks to markets and consumers. The FCA will nevertheless continue to closely monitor whether bespoke regulation is needed.

In October 2024, the FCA developed the AI Lab to help firms navigate AI adoption challenges.³³ The Lab features a regulatory sandbox providing access to data, compute, technical expertise and regulatory support.

In June 2025, the FCA also announced it will work with the ICO on a statutory code of practice for organisations developing or deploying AI.³⁴

Information Commissioner’s Office (ICO)

The ICO—the UK’s regulator responsible for upholding individuals’ information rights—published its first report on *Big Data and Data Protection* in 2014, and updated it in 2017 to include considerations related to AI and machine learning.³⁵

More recently, the ICO has published a suite of AI-specific guidance:

- Guidance on *AI and data protection*,³⁶ which clarifies the application of data protection principles to AI.

³⁰ Bank of England, ‘DP5/22 - Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning’, October 2022, <https://www.bankofengland.co.uk/prudential-regulation/publication/2022/october/artificial-intelligence>.

³¹ Bank of England, ‘Final report. Artificial Intelligence Public-Private Forum’, February 2022, <https://www.bankofengland.co.uk/-/media/boe/files/fintech/ai-public-private-forum-final-report.pdf>.

³² Bank of England, ‘FS2/23 – Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning’, October 2023, <https://www.bankofengland.co.uk/prudential-regulation/publication/2023/october/artificial-intelligence-and-machine-learning>.

³³ FCA, ‘AI Lab’, October 2024, <https://www.fca.org.uk/firms/innovation/ai-lab>.

³⁴ FCA, ‘Tech, trust and teamwork: How the FCA and ICO are helping innovation take off’, June 2025, <https://www.fca.org.uk/news/blogs/tech-trust-and-teamwork>.

³⁵ ICO, ‘Big data, artificial intelligence, machine learning and data protection, 2017, <https://ico.org.uk/media2/migrated/2013559/big-data-ai-ml-and-data-protection.pdf>.

³⁶ ICO, ‘Guidance on AI and data protection’, 2022, <https://ico.org.uk/for-organisations/uk-gdpr-guidance-and-resources/artificial-intelligence/guidance-on-ai-and-data-protection/>.

- Guidance on *automated decision-making and profiling*,³⁷ which assists organisations with applying UK GDPR provisions relevant to automated decision-making and profiling.
- Guidance on *explaining decisions made with AI*,³⁸ which provides practical advice on explaining AI-driven decisions to affected individuals.
- The *AI and Data Protection risk toolkit*,³⁹ which supports organisations in assessing risks during the AI lifecycle.
- Guidance on specific AI applications, such as biometric recognition⁴⁰ and age assurance technologies.⁴¹

The ICO also published an analysis on how specific areas of data protection law apply to generative AI systems; it launched a regulatory sandbox, which allows organisations to test innovative AI applications under ICO supervision; and, most recently, it published *Preventing harm, promoting trust*, a strategy which commits to developing a statutory Code of Practice for AI and increasing scrutiny on emerging risks posed by agentic AI and neurotechnology.⁴²

Ofcom

Ofcom is the UK communications and online safety regulator. Similarly to the FCA, it adopts a technology-neutral approach—it does not regulate AI as such, but rather the outcomes of its use within the sectors under its remit.

In the context of AI applied to communication services, Ofcom has focused on three risk areas:

- Synthetic media used to generate, among other things, content that depicts child sexual abuse, non-consensual pornography, and acts of terrorism, or used to spread mis- and disinformation.
- Content personalisation, which can lead to cases of price discrimination and to the amplification of illegal or harmful online content.
- Adversarial uses of advanced AI models that can harm the security and resilience of communication networks.

³⁷ ICO, 'Automated decision-making and profiling', 2022, <https://ico.org.uk/for-organisations/uk-gdpr-guidance-and-resources/individual-rights/automated-decision-making-and-profiling/>.

³⁸ ICO, 'Explaining Decisions Made with AI', 2022, <https://ico.org.uk/for-organisations/uk-gdpr-guidance-and-resources/artificial-intelligence/explaining-decisions-made-with-artificial-intelligence/>.

³⁹ ICO, 'AI and Data Protection risk toolkit', 2023, <https://ico.org.uk/for-organisations/uk-gdpr-guidance-and-resources/artificial-intelligence/guidance-on-ai-and-data-protection/ai-and-data-protection-risk-toolkit/>.

⁴⁰ ICO, 'Biometric data guidance: Biometric recognition', 2024, <https://ico.org.uk/for-organisations/uk-gdpr-guidance-and-resources/lawful-basis/biometric-data-guidance-biometric-recognition/>.

⁴¹ ICO, 'Age assurance for the Children's code', 2024, <https://ico.org.uk/media/about-the-ico/what-we-do/information-commissioners-opinions/age-assurance-for-the-children-s-code-1-0.pdf>.

⁴² ICO, 'Preventing harm, promoting trust: our AI and biometrics strategy', 2025, <https://ico.org.uk/about-the-ico/our-information/our-strategies-and-plans/artificial-intelligence-and-biometrics-strategy/>.

Ofcom's primary mechanism for AI oversight is the *Online Safety Act*, which requires platforms to mitigate risks amplified by algorithms and generative AI. In this respect, Ofcom has focused heavily on AI recommender systems and generative tools used to spread harmful content. It published the *Illegal Harms Codes of Practice*⁴³ as well as the *Protection of Children Codes*,⁴⁴ which set strict standards for age assurance and content moderation algorithms. In November 2025, Ofcom also published guidance promoting *A safer life online for women and girls*, which identifies specific areas where technology firms can do more to improve online safety for women and girls.⁴⁵

Moving forward, as stated in its *Strategic approach to AI 2025/2026*,⁴⁶ Ofcom will invest in technical research, including through sandboxes and technical labs, build a taxonomy for safety technology, and carry out horizon scanning work to understand new application areas such as agentic AI.

Approach to AI standardisation

Main features of the standardisation system

In the UK, standards have traditionally played an important role in supporting innovation and economic policies, including product safety, international trade, and competitiveness. Standardisation is a structural component of the UK's National Quality Infrastructure (NQI), the system of institutions and processes that ensures business and consumers have confidence that the products and services they purchase meet the relevant regulatory requirements.⁴⁷

The British Standards Institution (BSI) is the UK's only national standards body.⁴⁸ BSI is a private company. It operates independently from the government, but receives public funding in recognition of the strategic importance of its function. BSI's role is to contribute to improving the quality and safety of products, services and systems by enabling the creation of standards and promoting their use. BSI represents the UK

⁴³ Ofcom, 'Quick guide to illegal content codes of practice', November 2023, <https://www.ofcom.org.uk/online-safety/illegal-and-harmful-content/codes-of-practice>.

⁴⁴ Ofcom, 'Statement: Protecting children from harms online', April 2025, <https://www.ofcom.org.uk/online-safety/illegal-and-harmful-content/statement-protecting-children-from-harms-online>.

⁴⁵ Ofcom, 'A safer life online for women and girls', February 2025, <https://www.ofcom.org.uk/online-safety/illegal-and-harmful-content/a-safer-life-online-for-women-and-girls>.

⁴⁶ Ofcom, 'Strategic approach to AI', June 2025, <https://www.ofcom.org.uk/about-ofcom/annual-reports-and-plans/ofcoms-strategic-approach-to-ai>.

⁴⁷ GOV.UK, 'The UK's National Quality Infrastructure', August 2020, <https://www.gov.uk/guidance/the-uks-national-quality-infrastructure>.

⁴⁸ BSI, 'Memorandum of Understanding between the United Kingdom Government and the British Standards Institution in respect of its activities as the United Kingdom's National Standards Body', June 2002, <https://www.bsigroup.com/Documents/about-bsi/BSI-UK-NSB-Memorandum-of-Understanding-UK-EN.pdf>.

interests in international and European standard development organisations, and is responsible for the publication of international and European standards in the UK.

The UK government, through the Department for Business and Trade (DBT), sets the overarching standardisation policy, supports the development of standards—e.g., by sponsoring delegations representing the UK at international meetings and encouraging consumer representation in standardisation activities—and ensures the effectiveness of the country’s standardisation infrastructure and processes. As part of DBT, the Office for Product Safety and Standards (OPSS) manages funding to BSI and provides *ad hoc* resources for the development of specific standards. Various government departments lead on standardisation projects relevant to their remit. For instance, DSIT leads the government engagement around digital and telecommunication standards.

Two other institutional actors that contribute to standardisation activities and, like BSI, are part of the UK’s NQI are the National Physical Laboratory (NPL) and the UK Accreditation Service (UKAS). NPL is the National Metrology Institute and is responsible for developing and maintaining the UK’s primary measurement standards. UKAS is the National Accreditation Body and is appointed by the government to assess conformity assessment organisations that provide services including certification, testing, and inspection against standards and other norms.

As in many other jurisdictions, UK standards are voluntary. The government can designate specific standards—in part or in full—through a formal notice of publication on GOV.UK.⁴⁹ By adopting designated standards, manufacturers can claim a ‘presumption of conformity’ with the essential requirements of relevant product safety laws.

National AI-focused standardisation activities

AI standardisation in the UK is relatively advanced. At the time of writing, BSI’s committee on AI, ART/1, has published 43 AI standardisation deliverables, with ongoing work on 103 additional items.⁵⁰ Most of these are UK transpositions of standards and other deliverables developed at the international and European levels. They include both horizontal standards (e.g., AI management system)⁵¹ and issue-

⁴⁹ GOV.UK, ‘Designated standards: new or amended notices of publication’, July 2021, <https://www.gov.uk/guidance/designated-standards-new-or-amended-notices-of-publication>.

⁵⁰ BSI, ‘ART/1 - Artificial Intelligence’, 2026, <https://standardsdevelopment.bsigroup.com/committees/50281655#published>.

⁵¹ ISO/IEC 42001.

specific standards (e.g., risk management and bias).⁵² The two only strictly British standards developed by ART/1 are guidance on *data-driven organisations* and on *data-intensive projects*.⁵³

From a public policy perspective, standards are an integral component of the UK government's regulatory framework for AI. The UK's *Plan for Digital Regulation*⁵⁴ and the *National AI Strategy* outline the government's ambition to utilise standards as part of a broader range of non-regulatory tools for governing AI. In October 2022, to strengthen the UK's AI standards community and enable stakeholders to contribute to international standardisation activities, the government launched the AI Standards Hub. The Hub brings together the UK's technical expertise on AI standards, including the Alan Turing Institute, BSI, and NPL, to offer training and capacity building on the international AI standards landscape. The AI regulation white paper also indicated standards as a key tool that businesses can leverage to operationalise the AI regulation principles. The white paper proposed a 'layered approach' to applying relevant AI standards. Based on this approach, regulators should first encourage the adoption of sector-agnostic standards, which apply across AI use cases and support the implementation of the five AI regulation principles (e.g., standards on risk management and quality management systems). Second, regulators should encourage the adoption of standards on context-specific issues related to the application of AI (e.g., bias and transparency standards). Finally, regulators should encourage the adoption of sectoral standards to support compliance with specific regulatory requirements. The government's initial guidance for regulators on implementing the AI regulation principles represents a first step in this direction. Among other things, the guidance highlights specific standards that can be adopted to implement each AI regulation principle.⁵⁵

Engagement in international standardisation

The UK is especially active in international AI standardisation. BSI represents UK interests in international (ISO, IEC) and European (CEN, CENELEC, ETSI) standards development organisations. In addition to that, the UK government is committed to working with international partners to shape the international standard ecosystem consistently with its principles and values—e.g., innovation, openness, security, free trade and knowledge exchange—and champion the use of non-regulatory instruments

⁵² ISO/IEC 23894 and ISO/IEC 24027 respectively

⁵³ BS 10102-1:2020 and BS 10102-2:2020 respectively.

⁵⁴ UK. GOV, 'Digital Regulation: driving growth and unlocking innovation', July 2021, <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/digital-regulation-driving-growth-and-unlocking-innovation>.

⁵⁵ GOV.UK, 'Implementing the UK's AI regulatory principles: initial guidance for regulators', February 2024, <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/implementing-the-uks-ai-regulatory-principles-initial-guidance-for-regulators/implementing-the-uks-ai-regulatory-principles-initial-guidance-for-regulators>.

for the governance of AI.⁵⁶ This includes engaging with a wide array of institutions, multilateral processes, and stakeholder groups. A concrete example of the government's international engagement strategy is, once again, the AI Standards Hub, which supports international cooperation and capacity building on AI standards.

⁵⁶ GOV.UK, 'The UK's International Technology Strategy', March 2023, <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/uk-international-technology-strategy/the-uks-international-technology-strategy#foreword>.